CINEMA
HISTORICALS

A Burst of PATRIOTIC FERVOUR

Filmmakers are **revisiting India's colonial past** to bring our forgotten stories and heroes to life for future generations

By SUHANI SINGH



FREEDOM AT MIDNIGHT (2025)

For the past few years, all Nikhil Advani has been doing is directing dhoti-kurta-clad men rallying for freedom. He doesn't mind being labelled the chief chronicler of India's colonial history. It started with SonyLIV's *Freedom at Midnight* (2024-) whose second season will drop later this year, and continues with Amazon Prime series *Revolutionaries,* which he is currently shooting. "History fascinates me, especially this period. We cannot erase history. We should allow people to understand it and not take it for granted," Advani says, as he gets ready for a night shift of *Revolutionaries* unfolding on a sprawling set in Madh Island in Mumbai. If *Freedom at Midnight* captured how India's greatest leaders like Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru and Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel banded together for India's independence, *Revolutionaries*, Advani says, centres on a group of young boys with a more straightforward mission—"We will not ask them [the British] to leave, we will just throw them out."

Advani is not alone in mining India's colonial past for inspiration. Others, too, are focusing their lens on pivotal events and figures of the era. Recently, Ram Madhvani directed *The Waking of a Nation* (also on SonyLIV), a courtroom drama that documents the events leading up to the Jallianwala Bagh killings and follows one man's pursuit of truth and justice in its aftermath. Akshay Kumar's *Kesari Chapter 2* revisits the same incident, but tells it through the eyes of lawyer C. Sankaran Nair, "the forgotten hero" who "dared to take on the British Empire". Akshay plays Nair in the film, which has been in the news as BJP leaders target the Congress for ignoring Nair's contribution despite him being a former president of the INC (Indian National Congress). Later this year arrives Hansal Mehta's epic *Gandhi*, featuring Pratik Gandhi in the titular role. Rumour has it that a leading streaming platform has acquired the rights to the show. This spate of stories suggests that filmmakers are keen to take ownership of a troubling period of Indian history and revisit it with a fresh perspective. Through their work, they



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Filmmaker